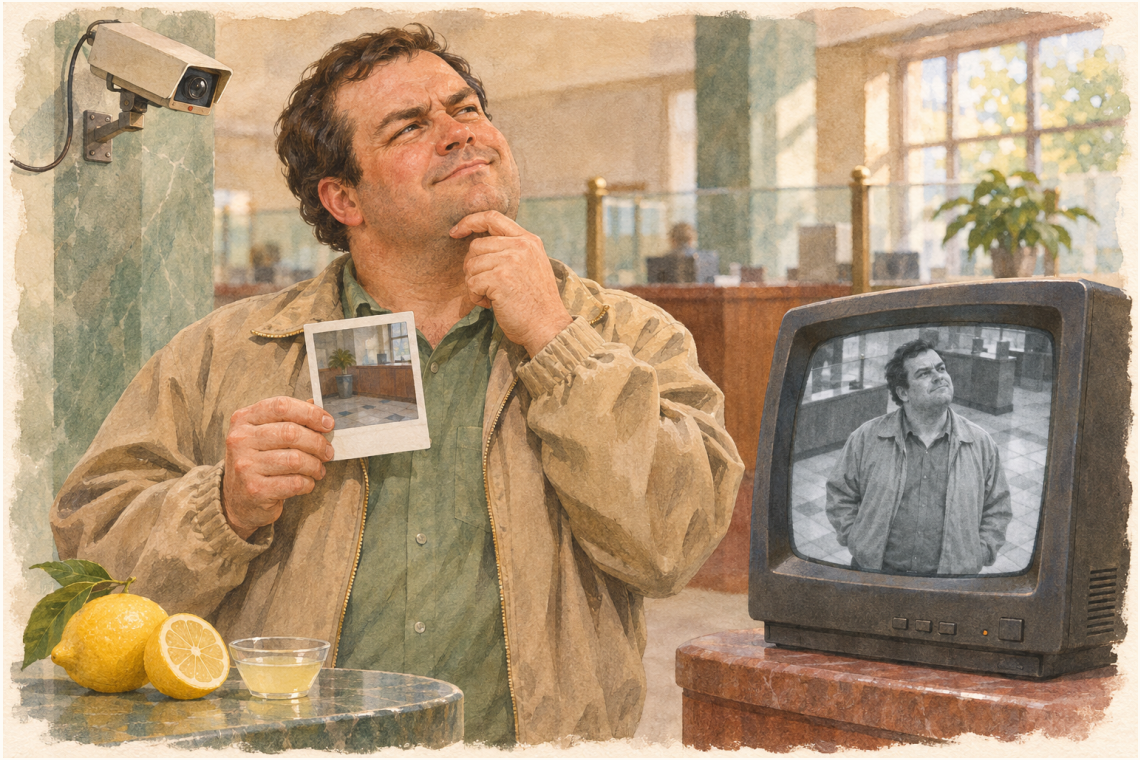
01

以为柠檬汁能隐身的劫匪

The Robber Who Thought Lemon Juice Made Him Invisible



我们为什么有时看不见自己的判断失误?

英文原文

On 6 January 1995, McArthur Wheeler and an **accomplice raided** two Pittsburgh-area banks at gunpoint **in broad daylight**, without **disguise**. Their only **camouflage** was lemon juice, **rubbed on** in the **earnest conviction** that it would **render** them invisible to cameras.

The **rationale** had a **kernel** of truth. Lemon juice is a **time-honoured** invisible **ink**, and Wheeler made an **inventive leap** from paper to skin. His Polaroid **self-portrait** came out **devoid of** its subject, a result he took as **conclusive**.

The security cameras **begged to differ**. On 19 April the eleven o'clock news showed **viewers** the **damning** images, and Wheeler was arrested shortly after midnight. **Confronted with** the tapes, he protested in **sheer disbelief** that he had worn the juice.

Reading about the case, the Cornell psychologist David Dunning **pondered** a **disquieting proposition**. Perhaps **incompetence** can **cloak** itself, **robbing** people of the **discernment** to notice their **deficiencies**.

For a 1999 **paper**, Dunning and his student Justin Kruger **quizzed** Cornell **undergraduates** on humour, grammar, and **logical** reasoning. The bottom quarter of **scorers** averaged the 12th percentile but **generously** placed themselves near the 62nd, whereas high **achievers** showed **undue modesty**. The **unskilled**, the authors argued, bear a **dual** burden, since **appraisal calls for** the same skills as **execution**.

Detractors traced part of the Dunning-Kruger **disparity** to regression to the mean, a statistical **mirage** the paper **partially** acknowledged. Studies designed to avoid it still find a smaller but **tangible** effect. In 2023 the pair **garnered** the Grawemeyer psychology award.

英文原文（续）

In fairness, Wheeler had tested his method **empirically** before **staking** his **liberty** on it. The camera that missed him was the one he turned on himself.

中文译文

1995年1月6日，麦克阿瑟·惠勒和一名同伙持枪抢劫了匹兹堡地区的两家银行，光天化日之下，不加乔装。他们唯一的伪装是柠檬汁，涂抹在身上，怀着真心实意的信念，认为它能使他们在镜头前隐形。

这套逻辑倒也有几分真实的内核。柠檬汁是一种由来已久的隐形墨水，惠勒则做了一次富有创意的跳跃，从纸面跳到了皮肤上。他的宝丽来自拍照洗出来后，完全没有照片的拍摄对象（他本人），这个结果，他当成了确凿的证据。

监控摄像头可不敢苟同。4月19日，11点新闻向观众播出了那些足以定罪的画面，午夜刚过不久，惠勒就被捕了。面对这些录像，他坚决表示完全不相信，说自己明明抹了柠檬汁。

读到这个案子时，康奈尔大学心理学家戴维·邓宁仔细思考了一个令人不安的观点。也许，无能（这种东西）会掩藏住它自己，剥夺人们的识别能力，去注意到他们自身的不足。

在1999年为了完成一篇论文，邓宁和他的学生贾斯汀·克鲁格测试了康奈尔的本科生，（考察了）关于幽默、语法和逻辑推理的能力。垫底的四分之一答题者，平均只处在（倒数）第12百分位，却大方地（高估自己）把自己估在第62百分位附近，而成绩优异者却表现出过分的谦虚。能力不足的人，两位作者认为，背负着双重负担，因为评估（自我评估）需要相同的技能，与执行（所需）的一样。

批评者查明部分邓宁-克鲁格差异，源于均值回归，一种统计学的假象，该论文（即前文1999年邓宁-克鲁格论文）也曾部分承认过。专为避开统计问题而设计的研究仍发现了一个较小但切实存在的效应。2023年，两人赢得了格文美尔心理学奖。

平心而论，惠勒确实用实证的方法检验过他的这套办法，在他把自己的自由赌在抢劫上之前。那台没拍到他的相机，正是他转动（将镜头）对准自己的那一台。

词汇与表达

accomplice n.
同伙
and an accomplice

raided v.
抢劫了
raided two Pittsburgh-area banks

in broad daylight n.
光天化日之下

disguise n.
乔装
without disguise

camouflage n.
伪装

rubbed on v.
涂抹

earnest adj.
真心实意的

conviction n.
信念
in the earnest conviction

render v.
使
render them invisible to cameras

rationale n.
逻辑
The rationale had a kernel of truth.

kernel n.
内核

time-honoured adj.
由来已久的

ink n.
墨水

inventive adj.
富有创意的

leap n.
跳跃

self-portrait n.
自拍照

devoid of adj.
完全没有

conclusive adj.
确凿的
a result he took as conclusive.

begged to differ phr.
不敢苟同

viewers n.
观众

damning adj.
足以定罪的

Confronted with v.
面对
Confronted with the tapes

sheer adj.
完全

disbelief n.
不相信

pondered v.
仔细思考了
pondered a disquieting proposition

disquieting adj.
令人不安的

proposition n.
观点
a disquieting proposition

incompetence n.
无能
incompetence can cloak itself

词汇与表达（续）

cloak v.
掩藏住

robbing v.
剥夺

discernment n.
识别能力
the discernment to notice

deficiencies n.
不足
notice their deficiencies

paper n.
论文
For a 1999 paper

quizzed v.
测试了

undergraduates n.
本科生

logical adj.
逻辑
logical reasoning

scorers n.
答题者

generously adv.
大方地

achievers n.
成绩优异者

undue adj.
过分的

modesty n.
谦虚

unskilled adj.
能力不足的

dual adj.
双重

appraisal n.
评估
appraisal calls for the same skills

calls for phr.
需要
calls for the same skills

execution n.
执行
the same skills as execution

Detractors n.
批评者

disparity n.
差异
the Dunning-Kruger disparity

mirage n.
假象

partially adv.
部分

tangible adj.
切实存在的
a smaller but tangible effect

garnered v.
赢得了

In fairness phr.
平心而论

empirically adv.
用实证的方法
tested his method empirically

staking v.
赌
staking his liberty on it

liberty n.
自由

文章简述

- 误信：惠勒知道柠檬汁能做隐形墨水，便误以为涂在皮肤上也能避开摄像头；自拍没拍到自己，他就认定办法有效。
- 落网：他涂着柠檬汁抢银行，仍被监控拍下，新闻播出后落网；看到录像，他还不相信“隐身”失败。
- 研究：案件启发邓宁和克鲁格测试大学生的幽默、语法及逻辑能力，发现低分者常高估自己，高分者反而低估。
- 双重负担：两人认为，能力不足先让人做不好；正因为缺少同一类能力，人也可能看不出自己错在哪里，把失败当成功。
- 限度：一次低分可能只是失常，未必代表真实水平，与自评比较可能夸大“高估”；后续研究尽量排除这类影响后，仍发现较弱的效应。